SPIRITUAL/RELIGIOUS FALSE BELIEF #109 · SUFFERING

“Complaining to God is a sin.”

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Where it often comes from

Verses about not grumbling applied to all honest prayer. Being told to always be thankful and never sad. A family where expressing frustration was punished. Fear that God will be angry if you tell Him how you really feel. Confusing respectful lament with rebellion.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture warns against grumbling, the bitter muttering that rejects God, like Israel in the wilderness. But it also gives us many prayers of honest lament. David said, “I pour out my complaint before Him; I reveal my trouble to Him.” Job spoke in the anguish of his spirit, and God later said Job had spoken accurately about Him. The psalmists asked, “How long?” Bringing your pain and frustration to God is an act of faith: you are taking it to the One who can help.

> *“I cry aloud to the LORD; I lift my voice to the LORD for mercy. I pour out my complaint before Him; I reveal my trouble to Him”* **(Psalm 142:1–2)**.

Also see

> “Therefore I will not restrain my mouth; I will speak in the anguish of my spirit; I will complain in the bitterness of my soul” **(Job 7:11)**.

> “How long, O LORD? Will You forget me forever? How long will You hide Your face from me? How long must I wrestle in my soul, with sorrow in my heart each day? How long will my enemy dominate me?” **(Psalm 13:1–2)**.

> “Trust in Him at all times, O people; pour out your hearts before Him. God is our refuge” **(Psalm 62:8)**.

> “O LORD, the God of my salvation, day and night I cry out before You. May my prayer come before You; incline Your ear to my cry” **(Psalm 88:1–2)**.

Common self-statements

- I shouldn’t tell God I’m upset.
- Good Christians never complain.
- God will be angry if I’m honest.
- I have to pretend I’m fine when I pray.
- Questioning God is rebellion.
- I should only thank Him, never vent.

Common logical errors

- **All-or-nothing thinking:** Treating all complaint as sinful grumbling.
- **Should statements:** “I should always sound grateful when I pray.”
- **Mental filter:** Overlooking the many laments in Scripture.
- **Projection:** Picturing God as unable to handle your honesty.

Challenging questions

- What did David do with his complaint in Psalm 142?
- What did God say about how Job spoke of Him?
- What is the difference between honest lament and bitter grumbling?
- Am I complaining to God or about God to others?
- Does God already know how I feel?
- Is pretending in prayer more honest or less?
- What do I need to pour out to God today?

Truth summary

> Bringing my complaints honestly to God is not a sin. Scripture is full of faithful people who poured out their troubles before Him. There is a difference between bitter grumbling that rejects God and honest lament that runs to Him. God already knows my heart, and He invites me to pour it out to Him.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Prayer, How to
- Sorrow
- Troubles
- Anger
- Trust

Listen: Overcoming Depression

Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "Complaining to God is a sin"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"Complaining to God is a sin." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What did David do with his complaint?
- ☐ What did God say about Job's words?
- ☐ Lament or grumbling: which is this?
- ☐ Am I complaining to God or about Him?
- ☐ Does God already know how I feel?
- ☐ What do I need to pour out today?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I can pour out my complaint before God.
- ☐ Honest lament is an act of faith.
- ☐ God already knows my heart.
- ☐ I can tell God how I really feel.
- ☐ God is my refuge when I am troubled.
- ☐ Lament runs to God; grumbling runs from Him.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **Psalm 142:1–2**
  "I cry aloud to the LORD; I lift my voice to the LORD for mercy. I pour out my complaint before Him; I reveal my trouble to Him."
- [ ] **Job 7:11**
  "Therefore I will not restrain my mouth; I will speak in the anguish of my spirit; I will complain in the bitterness of my soul."
- [ ] **Psalm 13:1–2**
  "How long, O LORD? Will You forget me forever? How long will You hide Your face from me? How long must I wrestle in my soul, with sorrow in my heart each day? How long will my enemy dominate me?"
- [ ] **Psalm 62:8**
  "Trust in Him at all times, O people; pour out your hearts before Him. God is our refuge."
- [ ] **Psalm 88:1–2**
  "O LORD, the God of my salvation, day and night I cry out before You. May my prayer come before You; incline Your ear to my cry."

A verse I found myself: _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Lament journal:** Each day, write an honest prayer about what troubles me, ending with one line of trust.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, Psalm 142:1–2 becomes: "**Sarah** cries aloud to the LORD; **she** lifts **her** voice to the LORD for mercy. **She** pours out **her** complaint before Him; **she** reveals **her** trouble to Him."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "Prayer, How to" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Write your own lament psalm:** your complaint, your request, and a statement of trust.
- ☐ **Read Psalm 13, 42, and 142,** and notice how each moves from complaint to trust.
- ☐ **Tell God one honest frustration aloud** in your own words today.
- ☐ **Share a lament with a trusted friend** and pray together.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "Complaining to God is a sin": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One honest lament I prayed
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~Complaining to God is a sin.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, thank You that I can pour out my heart to You. Help me reject the lie that complaining to You is a sin. Teach me to bring You my honest pain, to lament without bitterness, and to keep trusting You even when I don't understand. In Jesus' name, Amen.

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Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.